

RINGWORLD — IS LOVE THE ANSWER?

Event 96 · Ringworld RPG (1984 Ed) · Wheel-Spoke settlement & Rememberer's Vault · 6 players · 3 hours 30 min

She was expecting them. She does not entirely understand why. The bond is the scenario — everything else is scaffolding.

GM TRUTH

The landing crew sets down at Wheel-Spoke, a ring-shaped trading settlement. A young native named Serenthis intervenes when a crew member nearly triggers a collapse trap — she was expecting them. Serenthis is a Rememberer: a genetic lineage encoding dormant Protector-level knowledge, able to interface directly with ancient Ringworld systems. Ghresh-Ka, a Kzin warlord with eleven years of Ringworld patience, wants her as a key to the Rememberer's Vault beneath the spire. His lieutenant Serin is already in the market. His advance force arrives in twenty hours. The crew's ship power signature has inadvertently triggered a Ringworld weather cascade — the Foolish Endeavour must break orbit within 3.5 hours or sustain damage the ship cannot afford. The vault can grant Serenthis the power to repel Ghresh-Ka's entire force without violence — but the encoding will complete. She will begin the transition toward something like a Protector: hyper-intelligent, almost indestructible, and no longer human in the ways that matter. The person who walked into that vault will not be the person who walks out. The GM must identify the Bond Character before the Introduction ends. Watch who engages most with the Ringworld as a place.

■ INTRODUCTION — WHEEL-SPOKE LANDING (~15 min)

Locations: Landing craft clearing · settlement perimeter

The landing craft sets down 200 metres outside the settlement. Wheel-Spoke sits at the base of a spire rising into the upper atmosphere. The settlement is old — scrith foundation beneath newer construction, vivid, dense, loud. Vorn (comms): 'Weather systems are doing something I don't like. Keep the mission short.' Talren wants gravitational resonance samples. Brakk: 'If there's a problem, call early.' Mission: cultural survey, six hours before the Foolish Endeavour must reposition. This is what the mission brief says. Identify the Bond Character now.

Clues / handouts: 96-H01-B (Vorn's first weather warning — delivered end of Act 1)

■ ACT ONE — FIRST CONTACT (~60 min)

Locations: The Market Ring · The Collapse Trap · Serenthis's Workshop · Woven-Branch's arrival (act close)

Market: warm, chaotic, alive. Give each player one market moment — an odd item, an unusual trader, a strange custom. This is the only moment of pure joy the scenario provides. Use it. Collapse Trap: a dormant Ringworld maintenance system fires when a market stall owner shifts position on a contact panel. One crew member takes 1D6 and is pinned under debris. Before anyone from the crew reaches them: Serenthis is already there, places both hands on the wall, and the scrith lifts. She appears not surprised. She appears to have been expecting this moment. Workshop: small, layered with personal history. Maps on every wall — including a chamber beneath the spire not on any public survey. Artefacts include an interface token that grows warm when the Bond Character touches it. Serenthis: 'I have never seen it react before.' Serin (Ghresh-Ka's lieutenant) is in the crowd — Awareness to spot. Professionally neutral. She has no loyalty to Ghresh-Ka beyond contract and can be flipped if given a better offer or a convincing argument. Act ends when Woven-Branch arrives at the workshop, sees the off-worlders, and makes a decision — tells the crew what Serenthis is: 'Ghresh-Ka will be here by tomorrow's shadow cycle. And the vault will not wait that long.'

Clues / handouts: Serenthis lifts scrith [E1 — cannot be missed] · Workshop map of vault chamber [E2] · Serin in market crowd [Optional] · Token warms to Bond Character [Optional]

Pacing: At the 1:00 mark, trigger the collapse trap directly if the crew hasn't encountered Serenthis. She cannot wait past 1:15.

■ ACT TWO — THE COMPLICATION (~90 min)

Locations: Spire Base Passage · Rememberer's Vault · Vault Entrance exterior (defensive position) · Settlement perimeter

Passage: 200m descent, bioluminescent growth, gentle slope. A scrith iris partway down — sealed for centuries. Serenthis places her hand on the wall beside it and it opens. She is visibly shaken by the ease of it. This is the first time she has done this consciously, knowing what she is doing. Awareness: the iris shows signs of recent opening 3-4 times in the last decade. Vault: 40m chamber, domed, passive lighting activates fully when Serenthis enters. Walls covered in organic interface panels grown from scrith. Central column in Protector-script too ancient for any Known Space translation record. Computer + Linguistics (Hard): partial translation — emergency uplift mechanism for critical Ringworld maintenance failure. Computer + Linguistics + Science(Physics) (Extreme): full understanding — resulting entity contains Serenthis but is no longer limited to her. Whisper identifies the encoding mechanism via Research — and processes this as leverage before sharing it. Time the revelation for maximum narrative impact. Fallback if roll fails: Serenthis translates herself, haltingly, as if reading her own name in a language she learned this morning. She understands. She tells them. Ghresh-Ka's advance force of 6 mercenaries arrives at settlement perimeter (2:15 mark). Serin opens the gate if not addressed. Vorn (comms) at 60-minute mark: '...window now two hours and closing. If not on approach in 90 minutes, we reposition without you. Confirm receipt.'

Clues / handouts: Vault column translation [E3] · Whisper's encoding analysis [E4] · Serin's contract (if captured) — 'LIVING ONLY. Encoding must be intact.' [Optional]

Pacing: At 2:45 hard stop: Ghresh-Ka arrives at vault perimeter personally. Begin Act Three regardless.

■ ACT THREE — THE CHOICE (~30 min)

Locations: Three-mile sprint across open Ringworld surface · Landing Craft Clearing

Three miles, open terrain, storm wall building on horizon, Ghresh-Ka behind them. DEX×5: maintain pace without losing time. CON×5: sustain pace if already injured. Clearing: landing craft on standby. Storm front 15 minutes from this position. Ghresh-Ka's force 8 minutes away. Ghresh-Ka does not send his force ahead. He comes himself with two guards and calls a halt 200 metres out: 'I am not interested in your crew. I am not interested in your ship. Give her to me and you leave. We do not need to lose anyone today.' This is a genuine offer. He means it. He has waited eleven years. RR'raan may challenge him to single combat — Kzin honour exchange — Ghresh-Ka accepts, pausing his force. This buys time and may end the threat. MORAL DILEMMA — Serenthis speaks to the Bond Character: 'What do you want me to do?' Option A — Come With Us: she boards; encoding unresolved; leaves everything she has ever known; Ghresh-Ka thwarted without resolution. Option B — She Stays: crew departs; Woven-Branch's people visible at vault entrance; whether Serenthis survives the next confrontation — genuinely unknown. Option C — Vault Interface Completed (if crew reached vault in Act 2): she calls what she is becoming; storm responds; shadow squares shift; Ghresh-Ka's force dispersed without casualties; she is standing and breathing but already different. Option D — Crew Stays and Fights: miss the ship; Vorn returns in 6 hours; Bond Character chose her over the mission.

Pacing: At 3:10, Ghresh-Ka's terms expire. At 3:15, storm reaches landing zone. Ask the Bond Character directly: 'What do you say to her?'

■ EPILOGUE (~15 min)

Locations: Ascent / the aftermath

A — Taken: 'I could feel the vault from here. Until now... Is that what leaving always feels like?' Session ends on the Bond Character's answer. B — Left Behind: crew watches Ringworld surface recede. No closure. No confirmation she survived. The scenario leaves this open deliberately. C — Transformed: she raises a hand as the craft rises. The gesture is hers. What's behind the eyes may not be. Storm dissipates 30 minutes after departure. D — Stayed: six hours on Ringworld surface; Bond Character sits next to her waiting. Vorn returns. 'I'm filing the incident report. You're explaining it.'

KEY NPCS

Serenthis *Ringworld Rememberer, mid-20s — the scenario's centre*

STR 9 CON 12 INT 18 POW 17 DEX 13 APP 16 · HP 11 · Awareness 80%, Survival(RW) 85%, Linguistics(Ancient) 75%

Rememberer's Touch: direct contact with Ringworld interface systems — activates or calms them without technology. Open but guarded. Warm with Bond Character — unsettlingly so, as if she knew them. Will not be patronised. Has more courage than is healthy.

Woven-Branch *Elder of Wheel-Spoke — silver-braided hair (braid is a lineage record)*

History(Rememberer tradition) 85%, Persuade 65%, Linguistics(settlement dialects) 80% · HP 10

Knows the full Rememberer history. Three previous Rememberers attempted vault interface and were lost to transition. Suspicious of off-worlders. Will be honest if crew demonstrates they understand what is at stake.

Ghresh-Ka *Kzin Warlord — Ringworld Territorial Commander*

STR 22 CON 16 SIZ 20 INT 15 POW 13 DEX 16 · HP 18 · Armour 3pts (battle-mesh)

Claws 85%, Combat(laser carbine) 70%, Tactics 80%, Intimidate 85%, Command 75%. Does NOT charge. Manoeuvres. Never enters a room he cannot exit. Does not rage — he focuses. He is not wrong about the vault's power. He is catastrophically wrong about what it will do to the key.

Serin *Ghresh-Ka's lieutenant — mercenary, human female, early 30s*

Stealth 70%, Awareness 65%, Combat(laser) 75%, Combat(knife) 60%, Pilot(skimmer) 70% · HP 12

Dressed as a trader. Three gold teeth. Long scar on left hand covered with a glove. No ideological investment in Ghresh-Ka's project. Can be flipped for a better offer or a convincing argument about what happens to 'the key.'

HANDOUTS

96-H01-A — Serenthis's woven band — pattern is a lineage record, not decoration. Partial reading (no Linguistics): names and dates, 4 generations

96-H01-B — Vorn weather warning #1 — 'Weather systems doing something I don't like. Keep mission short.' (end Act 1)

96-H02-A — Partial vault column translation — ancient notation left, partial translation right. Several lines = question marks. Final lines missing.

96-H02-B — Vorn warning #2 — '...window now 2hrs and closing. If not on approach in 90min, we reposition without you. Confirm receipt.' (60-min mark, Act 2)

96-H02-C — Serin's contract (if she is captured or killed) — Serenthis's physical description, payment figure, 'LIVING ONLY. Encoding must be intact.'

THE TANGENT (post-session): Talren's data analysis reveals the vault's emergency uplift circuits activate only on critical Ringworld structural failure. Those circuits have been ACTIVE FOR 300 YEARS. The Ringworld is signalling that it has crossed a threshold. The Rememberer lineage is maintenance protocol — not an accident of nature, not an old Protector experiment. Serenthis — wherever she ended up — is a repair instruction. How many Rememberer lineages exist across the Ringworld? Are they all being called simultaneously?